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Round table

The 2018 Romanian protests: context and implications

Final Report



Overview

This final report aims to summarize and conclude what happened at the ICD event from 4th October 2018 with the title: The 2018 Romanian Protests: context and implications. The first part of this document provides detailed information about how the event was created and its organisational aspects, starting with the research on speakers, type of invitations that were sent and visuals. The second part concentrates on the event itself and how it was received by the audience. This report is a useful tool in order to assess and prevent further mistakes for future conferences.

In light of the recent protests that took place in Romania between 10-12th August 2018 and their relevance in today's European context, the ICD has brought together experts from the civic diaspora and the ICD international students at a round table debate, that transformed itself in a panel discussion with a Q&A session. The event was meant to establish a forum for discussion regarding the recent diaspora protests in Romania and their future implication for the country. The event was highly interactive and it brought the awareness of the international students to a specific country. All the topics proposed for this event were reached and given the current situation, the speakers also talked about the Referendum for redefining the family. To summarize the topics of the panel discussion were:

- A brief introduction to the current political situation in Romania;
- A chronological presentation of the recent history of Romania's protests;
- the culture of protests in Romania;
- the main reasons and purpose of the Romanian citizens going to a protest;
- the Romanian diaspora protest from 10-12th August 2018;
- The referendum for redefining the family; #boicot as an art of protest;
- The implications of this events for Romania and its presidency of the Council of the EU.

The event has engaged and inspired participants to keep up to date with the current political events in Romania and Europe and engaged in political discussions. The participation at this event was open to all individuals coming from the governmental and diplomatic fields, academia & scholars, artists, representatives from the civil society and private sector and journalists.

Program

Address: Institute for Cultural Diplomacy - 18-22 Soltau Str., 13509, Berlin. Date: 4th October, 2018. Timetable: from 5:30 to 7:00 pm.

Introductory Speech: Mr. Mark Donfried

Moderator : Ms. Alexandra Ioan Speakers from Diaspora Civica Berlin: Aleca Bunescu and Ioana Dragoș, Viviana Druga (performer) and Ramona Cara on behalf of the Rumänisch in Berlin Society.

Article about the event

On the evening of 4th October 2018 from 5:30 to 7:00 PM, the ICD Academy of Arts and Culture hosted the event entitled: The 2018 Romanian Protests: context and implications. The event started with an introduction speech from Mr. Mark Donfried, the director of the Institute for Cultural Diplomacy.

The panel discussion was moderated by Ms. Alexandra Ioan from the Civic Diaspora of Berlin (DCB) who, along with Ms. Aleca Bunescu and Ms. Ioana Dragoș from the same organisation, Ramona Cara on behalf of the Society Rumänisch in Berlin and the performer Viviana Druga discussed about the current political situation in Romania and the most recent protests from 10- 12th August 2018.

The conversation started with the moderators question to describe in a word the protests in Romania. From the way the speakers responded, the audience could notice that although they have different backgrounds and perspectives, their political ideologies were similar. The opinions of the speakers highlighted the complex ideology of protests and the political situation in Romania. Although the event was very informative and engaged to a political debate, the audience would have liked to see someone from a different political identification in order to have an open debate.

The recent events were briefly presented, in chronological order, starting with the 2012 protests against the mining project from Roșia Montană till the huge anti-corruption protests from August 2018, when tens of thousands of Romanians living in the Diaspora and not only, flooded the capital Bucharest for anti-government protests. Even though the protests were announced to be peaceful, more than 400 people were injured, as the police forces used water cannons and teargas to disperse protesters calling on the government to resign. At the European Parliament, the recent raft of controversial judicial reforms was criticized as going the way Hungary and Poland did, which are already facing legal actions from Brussels over alleged moves to weaken the rule of law.

The last subject added to the discussion was the one of the referendum regarding the definition of the family in the Romanian Constitution and prohibiting the same-sex marriage. The conference brought the awareness of the guests and the ICD Students to this intense discussed topics and according to their feedback, the event was very well moderated, interesting and highly successful. Below are some of the comments about the round table.

1. Pros

Opinion A: Good choice of speakers. They covered well the topics that were brought to the table and added a broad range of different aspects of the initial hypothesis: education in Romania, culture, demography, political and social situation. It was interesting to see how each of them had a different point of analysis on the different topics, but in the end they all took the same position regarding

the protests and the politic in Romania in general. The moderator was particularly good: not only she knew the good timing of how to articulate the debate, but also she could pitch in at the right moment when moving to a new topic.

Opinion B: Very nice and interesting discussion, good topic, interesting speakers. I really liked that artists were involved - it made the event more alive, we could hear different point of views. I think it is important to invite speakers from different fields, with different political opinions, different age, occupation, etc... I liked it that the moderator knew what she was doing, was well informed and made sure we follow the timetable.

Opinion C: The moderator was very good. The questions were very well chosen so that the students and guests understand what has happened in Romania during 10-12 August and before. Given the fact that the event took place 2 days before the Referendum for redefining the family, I enjoyed that they talked about that as well.

Opinion D: Speakers shared a lot of interesting points of view. They genuinely wanted to explain the situation in Romania but also to listen to the audience's feedback, comments and questions. The atmosphere for the event was formal, but very open and honest. The moderator is very experienced in hosting events and did a great job to lead, provide suggestions and encourage the speakers to speak up. The speaker that works as a social worker provided a real and practical view about what actually happened in Romania. The art performer speaker brought unique opinions about the situation and was very straight forward with her sharing.

Opinion E: Interesting topic and contributing to the development of democracy. Well informed speakers who cared about the topic and their country in general

2. Cons

There were only two critics from the event. The audience thought the debate would benefit from having speakers with a different political background, to have an opened and broader debate and in the same time they would have liked if the questions from the audience would have been taken at the moment they were announced.

Visuals



ROUND TABLE

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BERLIN, 4TH OCTOBER, 2018

FROM 5:00 TO 7:00 PM



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Overview

In light of the recent protests that took place in Romania and their relevance in today's European context, the ICD endeavors to bring together experts and students in a round table debate. The event is meant to establish a forum for discussion regarding the recent protests in Romania and their future implication for the country and for the EU.

The highly interactive round table will explore several topics, such as:

- the current political situation in Romania;
- the recent history of Romania's protests;
- their implications for Romania;
- their implications for Romania's presidency of the Council of the EU, if any.

The round table is designed to provide an interactive platform for discussion on the topic of the recent demonstrations in Romania and their implications on different levels. The event aims to engage and inspire participants to keep up to date with current political events in the European landscape, as well as encourage and foster critical thinking. The round table also aspires to empower participants to engage in political discussions and initiate constructive changes in the political and social landscape.

Participation in the session is open to all individuals coming from the governmental and diplomatic fields, academia & scholars, representatives from the civil society and private sector, journalists, artists, young students and professionals.



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Speakers

REPRESENTATIVES OF THE CIVIC DIASPORA BERLIN

Together we resist. Together we build

Civic Diaspora of Berlin is an organization born in February 2017, following the street protests in Romania and Germany, which aims to increase the civic and political involvement of the members of the Romanian diaspora in Berlin and Germany. (more information under:<https://diasporacivica.com/>)



Alexandra Ioan (Moderator)

Ms. Ioan is interested in civil society organizations. She is collaborating with Romanian and international NGOs in the development of non-formal educational programs and strengthening of civic involvement and democracy.

Alexandra studied Communication and Public Administration Management in Bucharest. In Berlin she did a Master of Public Policy at Hertie School of Governance. Because her interest in the public and civic sector has grown even more, she continued with a Good Governance PhD.



Aleca Bunesu

Ms. Bunesu studied architecture in Hanover. She loves art, photography and art theory, a field in which she has had several projects. For over 6 years, Aleca has been working in Berlin where she hopes to save the world from poor quality architecture and improve the quality of life. Within the Civic Diaspora of Berlin, Aleca found a community of people with whom she gathers forces into building a better future for the Romanian society.



Laura Lupea

Ms. Lupea studied medicine at the Ludwig Maximilians Universität in Munich works as a psychiatrist in Berlin. In the Civic Diaspora of Berlin, Laura met people with a beautiful and good soul, people who dream away, but they know how to make their voices heard for an imminent change in the Romanian society.

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Speakers



Rumänisch in Berlin

The Romanian in Berlin professional team consists of social workers, social educators, linguists, economists and many others. They have many years of work experience, especially in social work and in the work of German and European non-governmental organizations (NGOs). The main interests of this organisation are Community Building, Social Work, Art and Culture. The representative of this society is Mr. Marius Krauss.

(<http://www.rumaenisch.berlin/Startseite/>)



Viviana Druga

Ms. Druga is a Romanian ritualista based in Berlin who uses performance and photography and installation based work as her main forms of expression. She was predominantly interested in the social side of art, performing activist art actions in Bucharest such as infiltrating the international biennial, photographing herself with the president on the street while being dressed like a guerrilla, and convincing people to pose in their swimsuits in winter at a busy intersection where an off-limits park had been constructed. Since she moved to Berlin, she has been investigating the personal, poetic side of performing, the new dimensions of reality and capturing that reality through photography – using art as a magical activity that can help the subject / audience discover new dimensions of oneself. (<https://vivianadruga.com/about/>)



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A brief historical overview of the Romanian protests

Country profile

Romania (capital: Bucharest) is a country in Southeast Europe that was under the communist rule of Nicolae Ceaușescu from 1948 until 1989. The early protests of the violent Romanian Revolution occurred in the city of Timișoara in mid - December 1989, when Romanians sought a change in government following recent events in neighboring nations. The Securitate, the secret police force, proved powerless in stopping the revolt. Since 1990, free elections were held. In 2004, the country joined the North Atlantic Treaty Organization (NATO), and in 2007 it became a member of the European Union (EU).

The recent history of Romania's protests

Recent protests started on a small scale in January 2012, after attempted health system reforms. At the time, the government resigned. In September 2013, tens of thousands of people protested against a Canadian mining project at Roșia Montană that would have destroyed local cultural heritage. Months later, the project was abandoned.

Over the past few years, PSD (Social Democratic Party) has lost substantial battles against Romanian protesters. The party was forced out of government in 2015, following large demonstrations regarding a deadly fire at a Bucharest nightclub. In February 2017, a half-million people took to the streets to oppose an emergency decree that effectively decriminalized low-level corruption, raising concerns from the European Commission and the US state department.



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Since then, the Social Democrat-led government has continued to push through legislation. Discontent escalated when the Social Democrat leader, Liviu Dragnea, sentenced to three and half years of prison by the Supreme Court in June 2018 for incitement to abuse of office, tried to change the Penal Code, so that he would not face the charges. Anti-government demonstrations have become a regular occurrence in Romania, but in recent months numbers have dropped significantly as fatigue has set in. The protests on Friday, August 10th were the largest in months.

Romanian Diaspora Protests in August 2018

On August 10th, 2018, tens of thousands of members of the Romanian diaspora have returned to the capital and their home cities to express their growing discontent with the current government. The demonstration took a bad turn, as some inflamed protesters fought the military police to enter the government building. The consequent decision of the military police to evacuate all protesters after 10 pm from the square resulted in hundreds of people inhaling tear gas or being pushed around.

More resources on the topic are available at:

<https://theglobepost.com/2018/08/28/framing-corruption-romania/>

<https://www.theguardian.com/world/2018/aug/11/hundreds-injured-in-romania-protests-as-emigrants-return-to-fight-corruption>

<https://www.nytimes.com/2018/08/10/world/europe/romania-protests.html>



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The Institute for Cultural Diplomacy (ICD) focuses on the development and the promotion of the field of Cultural Diplomacy with the aim to raise awareness and understanding of the field across the globe both locally and internationally.

The ICD works continuously to develop new and innovative initiatives of cultural diplomacy.

The goal of the institute is to promote global peace and stability by strengthening and supporting intercultural relation at all levels.

For more information about the Institute please visit

www.culturaldiplomacy.org